Honecker – a young girl dressed in a FDJ shirt pushed to the front of the crowd and gave a speech. Pravda Correspondent P. Naumov recalled:

We could not understand what she was speaking about, but after some hours, the American radio in West Berlin, RIAS, reported that she cautioned the workers to be careful. She said: 'We in the FDJ were sent here to spy on you.' The throng of people supported her. They applauded with roaring approval.

Naumov was flabbergasted at the SED's 'complete ignorance of the mood of the masses, lack of connection with the classes, an inability to speak to the people'.3 Having witnessed the chaos in the House of Ministries, Honecker dashed over to the FDJ headquarters, a broad-beamed building near the Brandenburg Gate. After bounding up the stairs, he told subordinates, 'It's getting serious, we'll defend the building in an emergency, weapons are ready. The most important thing is that we, as the Party's cadre reserve, stand firmly and united around Comrade Ulbricht, on whom the class enemy is now aiming fire.' Never before had the SED so obviously lost control of its own patch. Back in the House of Ministries, chaos mounted, as fevered discussions moved from room to room and across corridors. By mid-afternoon, Ulbricht was forced to withdraw the higher productivity quotas but as word of his decision spread, events were already careening out of control as calls for a general strike mounted. The die was cast, and by eventide RIAS was broadcasting news of the planned strike with details of times and locations: 'Tomorrow morning, 6.30 am at Strausberger Platz,' a square in the Friedrichshain-Kreuzberg district. In contrast, GDR radio aired emergency programmes, with all scheduled broadcasts, including news bulletins, dropped.

Before too much time passed, Soviet representatives convoked a meeting to discuss evacuating the families of Politburo members. In no doubt about the gravity of the situation, a visibly upset Honecker attempted, albeit unsuccessfully, to convince Margot to seek haven with the Russians. 'That